# Data Our Bodies Tell: Toward Critical Feminist Action in Fertility and Period Tracking Applications

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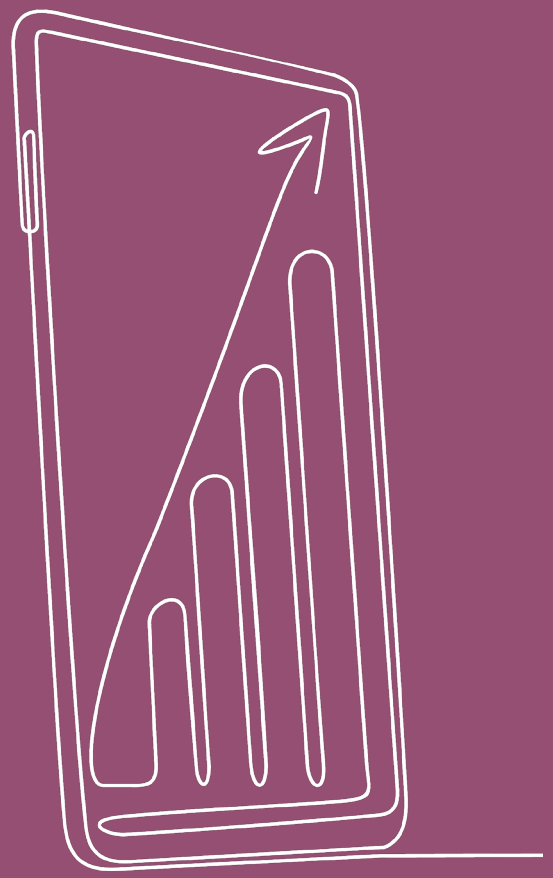
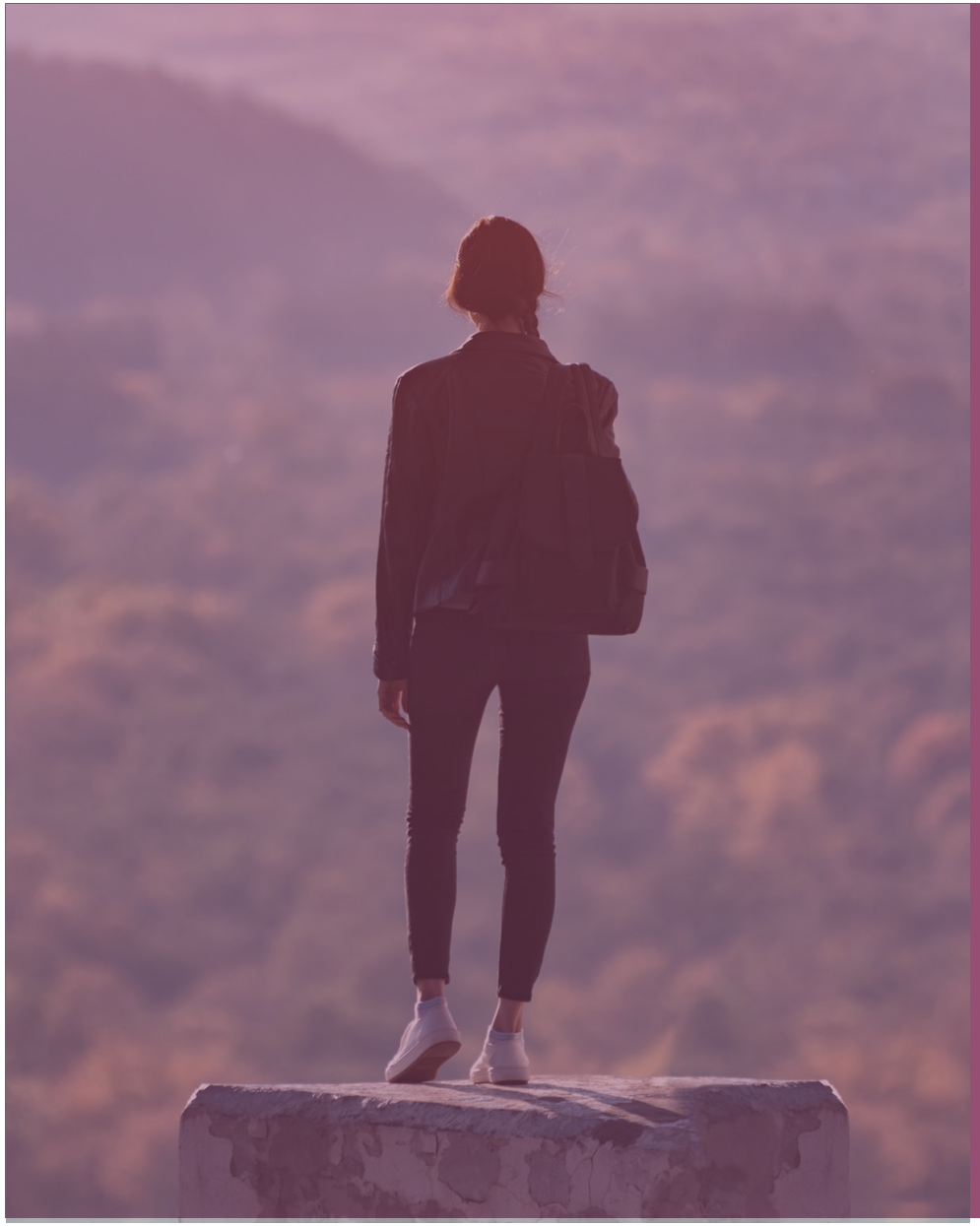
In "Data Our Bodies Tell: Toward Critical Feminist Action in Fertility and Period Tracking Applications," authors Maria Novotny and Les Hutchinson claim to situate feminist action in technical communication by applying critical imagination to look in places, at practices and conditions that have not been considered enough.



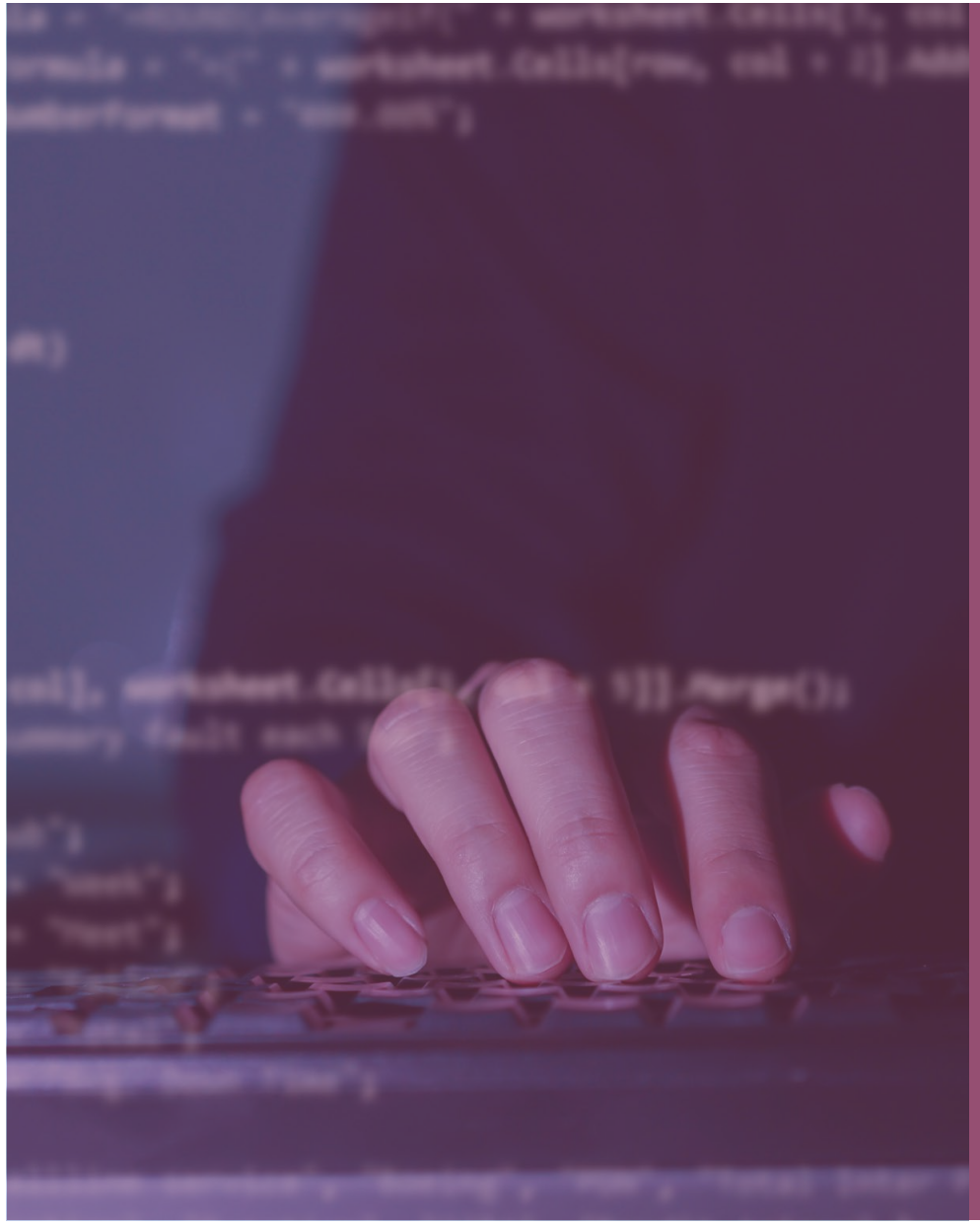
They intend to explore the question of how much agency users have over their reproductive health when using fertility tracking apps.

The authors chose the Glow app for their study because of the "strategic marketing in the launch" of this app, promoted by two tech executives. They plan to examine "how this application promises user self-empowerment at the expense of commodifying private health data."



Novotny and Hutchinson "point to gaps in which the application actually erodes user agency" and reference the statement by researchers Frost and Haas that "women are indoctrinated into a culture that expects us to look outside of our bodies to assist us in determining and confirming what is happening inside our bodies."

In this light, the authors claim that Glow "should take [sic] more explicit efforts to make clear when and how users give up their data to Glow." This is because, as with many apps, Glow does not require users to review Terms of Service and Privacy Policy documents as part of the download and consent process.



The app’s Terms of Service state that Glow is the sole owner of the user information collected, but it is not clear how Glow commercializes user data. Consumer Reports also found security and privacy flaws in the app.

The authors conclude that "Glow's data collection policies erode user agency" and therefore the app is "supportive of the company rather than its users."

Novotny and Hutchinson assert that "technical communicators are well suited to make the process of obtaining consent, and the language of what is being consented to, more apparent by redesigning ToS and PP documents to be more transparent."

The authors:

- Suggest that the app interface undergo a "more ethical, human-centered redesign“
- Provide recommendations to make "all facts [sic] of data collection transparent"
- Make suggestions for increasing user control of data.

# Questions for Reflection and Discussion

Write about any of these topics in your discussion post.

What ethical frameworks discussed in other readings can you identify underlying the "critical feminist action" the authors claim they are performing in this article? What framework(s) might apply, and how?

2

Some feminists have analyzed how society has historically defined women by, and encouraged us to focus on, our capacity for childbearing. How might this critique apply to the concept and the personal and social impacts of fertility tracking apps?

3

Metaethics: What is the purpose of technology? Do personal health data tracking applications fulfill or conflict with that purpose? How?

4

Generally speaking, when, how, where and why are app users' needs in tension with or opposition to tech company priorities?

5

What do you think the authors mean when they write "fertility and period tracking applications allow users access to their menstrual data" or that these apps "increase one's autonomy and access to personal health data"? Do you agree with these assertions? Why or why not?

6

The authors write, “…we find the exorbitant out-of-pocket costs associated with fertility treatment and alternative family-building, a social justice issue that should be taken up by feminist technical communicators."

- What definition of "family" underlies this statement?
- Is anyone left out of this definition of family?
- Do alternatives to fertility treatment for "family-building" exist?
- If so, do those alternatives diminish the importance of fertility treatment as a social justice issue?

Thank you! I look forward to reading your posts.